Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "pink = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

Pink is the colour of **skin, cheeks and lips**, that is, the colour of a living body. A blossoming apple tree, a peony, ripening fruit, dawn. In nature it often appears **briefly and gently**, and that is why it gives us a feeling of something fragile and precious.

From culture

In Europe, pink was long linked with **childhood, girls and sweets**, although in the eighteenth century it was the colour of courts and of men. Today we see it with **two faces**. Sometimes as tenderness and care, sometimes as a bold and defiant colour. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

A childhood ribbon, grandma's peonies, a first lipstick, a birthday cake, a pink room you did not choose, or a toy someone pushed on you instead of the one you wanted. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same pink** and one feels tenderness, the other pressure.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "pink" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does pink connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

Pink has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where we begin.

Pink was not always for little girls

As a colour name, the word "pink" appears in English at the end of the seventeenth century and comes from the flower called the carnation (Dianthus), which is known in English as pinks. In the eighteenth century pink was **the colour of courts**. Madame de Pompadour, the favourite of Louis XV, wore it, and the Sèvres manufactory made a special shade of porcelain for her. Pink was worn regardless of gender.

As late as **1918**, the American trade magazine Earnshaw's Infants' Department wrote that the common rule was pink for boys and blue for girls. Another catalogue advised the opposite at the time. The fixed division settled only in the 1940s, following what shops offered. First Lady **Mamie Eisenhower** helped too, with her pink gown at the 1953 inauguration. Today's link between pink and girls is therefore **not a law of nature**.

Shocking pink

The Italian designer Elsa Schiaparelli mixed magenta with a little white in the early 1930s and created **shocking pink**. This is no longer about inconspicuous tenderness, but a colour that wants to be seen.

The name magenta is interesting in itself. The dye was first called fuchsine, after the fuchsia flower, and in 1860 it was renamed after **the Battle of Magenta** of June 1859. Pink can thus mean an idea, provocation and boldness. Some pinks whisper. Others have already ordered a microphone.

The pink cell that was meant to calm

In the 1970s the American researcher Alexander Schauss described a shade he called **Baker-Miller pink**. In **1979** he persuaded the management of a naval prison in Seattle to paint its cells with it. The report said that after fifteen minutes the tendency toward violence dropped. The story quickly spread to prisons, classrooms and sports changing rooms.

Later controlled experiments, however, **did not confirm** the promise. A 1988 study found no effect on pulse or strength. In 2014, aggression among prisoners fell the same in a pink room as in a grey one. Pink is not a remote control for the nervous system. It may feel pleasant to you, but do not expect it to calm everyone.

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